



SpaceX's exploding rockets

Starship mishaps that fueled the future

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“The path to Mars is paved with fireballs.” That’s not SpaceX’s official slogan, but it might as well be. In its quest to build the most powerful, fully reusable rocket in history, SpaceX has embraced a development style that’s as bold as it is combustible. The Starship program, aimed at ferrying humans to the Moon and beyond has seen success, and some spectacular failures.

SpaceX Starship 36 in June 2025

There wasn’t even time for a count-down. Ship 36 was on the stand, being fueled for a static fire test, all standard procedure. But then something went really wrong. A high-pressure nitrogen tank inside the nose, a piece of plumbing known as a COPV, ruptured. The result was a concussive explosion that lit up the night sky and ripped

apart the prototype before it could even prove itself. Luckily, no one was hurt. But the timeline for Starship’s tenth test flight suddenly got a lot less certain.

SpaceX Flight 9 in May 2025

The ninth flight was ambitious. Starship was meant to deploy eight Starlink dummy satellites and test how it handled reentry with 100 heat-shield tiles intentionally removed. But space doesn’t reward ambition, it tests it. Midway through reentry, a leak in the fuel system triggered a slow-motion failure. The vehicle began to spin. Contact was lost. Somewhere over the Indian Ocean, it silently broke apart.

SpaceX Starship Flight 8 (March 2025)

It started with triumph: for the first time, the Super Heavy booster was caught mid-air by the towering “chopsticks” on the launch tower, a futuristic ballet of robotics and rockets. But then came the second act. As the Starship upper stage continued its journey, four engines shut down. The rocket began to lose control before finally breaking apart over the Atlantic. One step forward, one explosion back.

SN10 (March 2021): Land, Stand and Detonate

For a few glorious minutes, SN10 looked like a breakthrough. The rocket soared to 10 kilometers, flipped into a belly flop, and then, against all expectations, landed upright. The team at SpaceX erupted in cheers. Eight minutes later, they were picking up the pieces. Flames at the rocket’s base, likely fueled by pooling methane, led to a late explosion that launched it into the air once again. **d**

Axiom 4: Indian in Space

Group Captain Shubhanshu Shukla became the first Indian in space since Rakesh Sharma, aboard the Axiom-4 mission on June 25, 2025. The SpaceX Crew Dragon “Grace” lifted off from NASA’s Kennedy Space Center, carrying an international crew to the ISS for a 14-day scientific mission. This historic flight marks India’s return to human space-flight after 41 years and advances its ambitions in space exploration.



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